

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 1/8: 1. Definition and possibility test

CAN RELIGION EXIST WITHOUT A CREATOR GOD?

religion may organise:

ultimate concern | sacred value | ritual | community | moral discipline

worldview | transformation | liberation

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THEISM is sufficient for many religions, not conceptually necessary for all

test a tradition by doctrine + practice + soteriology, not by a Western creator template

TRAP: non-theistic != atheistic; silence, irrelevance and denial are different positions.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 2/8: 2. Four negative positions

ATHEISM: denies that God exists

AGNOSTICISM: suspends judgement because knowledge/evidence is insufficient

NON-THEISM: God is absent or non-central to the path

ANTI-THEISM: holds God-belief harmful or false in a stronger evaluative sense

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IGNOSTICISM: “God” must be made meaningful before existence is debated

practical atheism: life organised without reference to God

keep epistemic suspension separate from metaphysical denial.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 3/8: 3. Buddhism

FOUR NOBLE TRUTHS → dependent origination → eightfold path → nirvāṇa

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no eternal creator is needed; suffering has conditioned causes, not divine decree

devas may occur in cosmology but are impermanent and unsaving

Buddha rejects speculative questions when they do not conduce to cessation of duḥkha

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objection: karma/order functions like hidden providence

reply: causal-moral regularity is impersonal; no omnipotent allocator or creator follows.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 4/8: 4. Jainism, Mīmāṃsā and Sāṃkhya

JAINISM: eternal jīva/ajīva; karmaic matter; tīrthankara teaches, not creates

MĪMĀṂSĀ: authorless eternal Veda; ritual action generates apūrva; no divine author needed

SĀṂKHYA: prakṛti evolves for plural puruṣas; unconscious teleology without creator

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shared anti-creator pressure: if God is perfect, why create? if embodied, who made body?

distinctions: Jainism retains worshipful exemplars; Mīmāṃsā centres dharma/ritual;

Sāṃkhya centres discriminative metaphysics and kaivalya.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 5/8: 5. Cārvāka as limit case

CĀRVĀKA denies God, afterlife, karma, Vedic authority and mokṣa

embodied this-worldly flourishing replaces salvation

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DOES IT COUNT AS RELIGION?

doctrinal-historical member of Indian philosophical debate: YES

sacred/transcendent/soteriological practice in robust sense: largely NO

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limit case shows that “philosophy without God” is easier than “religion without God”;

Buddhism/Jainism better preserve ritual, community and liberation functions.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 6/8: 6. Nietzsche and post-theism

"GOD IS DEAD" = collapse of the Christian metaphysical value horizon

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danger: nihilism, herd morality exposed, no transcendent guarantor

task: revaluation of values -> self-overcoming -> life-affirmation

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not a simple empirical proof that no deity exists

objection: self-created values risk arbitrariness or domination

reply: genealogy tests inherited values; affirmative creation accepts responsibility

POST-THEISM asks what religious depth survives after classical supernatural belief.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 7/8: 7. Naturalism and fictionalism

RELIGIOUS NATURALISM: nature is ultimate; awe, gratitude, ritual and ethics without supernaturalism

FICTIONALISM: participate in God-language/practice without literal ontological assent

SEA OF FAITH / non-realism: religious symbols shape life rather than report a transcendent entity

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objections: worship without real object is make-believe; prayer loses address; truth is sacrificed

replies: symbols and communal narratives can disclose value and transform conduct

pressure remains: can function alone preserve religion's claim to truth and transcendence?

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 8/8: 8. PYQ and qualified verdict

DEFINE religion by clustered features -> distinguish four negative positions

- > demonstrate Buddhism/Jainism/Mīmāṃsā/Sāṃkhya -> use Cārvāka boundary
- > Nietzsche/post-theism -> naturalism/fictionalism -> objection on truth/object

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VERDICT BY CRITERION

creator-belief necessary? NO | ultimate concern/ritual/transformation possible? YES
personal worship and providence preserved? often NO

CLOSE: religion without God is coherent, but not religion without any ultimate value,
disciplined practice, communal form or account of transformation.